Fall 2019 VE496
Lecture notes
Week 8

Your self-evaluation

Weakness	Strengths
– No or little eye contact – Stiff body – No connection with audience – No story to tell – Too much info on slides – Nervousness – “Emotionless lecture”	– Good eye contact – Good visual aids – Sound logic – Good organization – Clear bullet points – Limited text – Good storytelling (1 student)

No one wants to read long blocks of text.

Both of the speakers say that many bad presentations often make people sleepy.

In "How to avoid death by PowerPoint," David JP Phillips gives us five suggestions for making slides. The first one is one message per slides. This is really convenient for audiences because their energy is limited. Audience can't focus on many information at the same time. One message per slide is enough. The second one is working message, which means speaking with text on slides makes audience remember nothing. A picture with few words enhancing the picture can help a lot. People can't get information from reading and listening at the same time, so just putting the PowerPoint materials, giving a picture and interpreting will deepen the impression of audiences. The third is size. Using the bigger font size for more important information is also useful. In a slide, the biggest font can attach most of the attention, so to make people understand easily, the important thing like heading should be in big size. The fourth is contrast, using contrast to make key points stand out. A slide with many words, sentence, or data will make people don't know where they should focus, but give the most contrast part to what is important will remind people what they should look at clearly and make them focus. The last is that the number of objects in a slide shouldn't exceed six. David gives an example that people just use 0.2s to count 5 balls, but they pay 500% more time and energy to count 7 balls. If speaker can make people spend less energy, people will feel better when listen to the presentation. This video teaches us how make people comfortable to see the content.

In "Story, Imagery, & the Art of 21st Century Presentation," Garr Reynolds shows that nowadays, many Japanese uses a lot of texts on their slides. Then, he points out that it's wrong and it makes people sleepy. He suggests speakers should be storyteller and the most important thing in presentation is idea not text. Using the vision material can help people understand better like video. Video can be emotion generator to resonate with others. His statement is really helpful because rather than text, story or video can attract people better. Thus, story and video can help people engage with the presentation and then understand the ideas of speakers deeply.

When I give presentation, I really pay attention to how to make the slides look good. Thus, I do well in the ideas of the first video, one message per slide, size, etc. Making slides looks good is my strength. However, I often think the text is the most important part of presentation and usually I am just a speaker rather than storyteller. Few stories and interesting visual materials make audiences don't engage a lot. The second video tells me that being a storyteller is where I should improve.

This is better, but there is still a better way

In the first video, David talks about several tips about PowerPoint. The first tip is that there should not be too many information in one slide, and one piece of information is fine. The second tip is that the objects with contrast can draw more attention from the audience. Third, the most important information should be the largest. Fourth, the background should not be white or some bright color but dark. Fifth, long sentences should be avoided in slides. Sixth, there should be no more than six elements in one page. Then in the second video, Garr talks about the story about her mother, and the role that the video and films play in such story. Although with the time flies, many things have been changed, the rich emotions inside it can impress people, and it should be applied in our slides.

Listing as a technical communication strategy:

In the speech "How to avoid death by PowerPoint" by David JP Phillips, he offered us with five key principles to optimize PowerPoints, which include:

1. One massage: only put one single massage per slide
2. Working memory: pull down speaking message and save area for presentation materials (like pictures)
3. Size: the most important information (but not headline) should be biggest
4. Contrast: contrast is used to control focuses, no white background of PPT (screen catches attention rather than the presenter)
5. Objects: no more than 6 objects on a slide

These five principles are quite enlightening, especially the forth one. We've never considered how PowerPoints could distract attention through being of higher contrast. PPTs should always be an assistant rather than the leading actor in a presentation. Also, the number of contents matters as counting costs lots of time and also distracts people.

In the speech "Story, Imagery, & the Art of 21st Century Presentation" by Garr Reynolds, the speaker pointed out some key points to improve the slides and presentation:

1. Use vivid images and visual materials instead of long sentences, data and paragraph.
2. Presented idea is what really matters and should be paid the most attention to
3. Use videos to amplify the story told
4. Connect people to a deeper level

Presentations can also be vivid and attractive if images, stories and arts are used properly and listeners can be saved from being bored and sleepy. However, special attention should also be paid to the main theme, which should always be the core of the presentation, around which the presentation PPT is designed.

To be more professional, I prefer to list evidence like charts, quotations in PPT, which is typically boring. The reason I do PPT in this way is that for engineers we cannot avoid presenting or listing some literature review or mathematical concepts. Often, I cannot present like a story teller, instead like am emotionless lecture. In terms of Garr's suggestion, I think, in the future, I can explain some abstruse concept by telling a story so that everyone can understand and get the point. However, in the presentations by engineers, we probably cannot use photos as the major object of the presentations, especially under occasions like design reviews of the Capstone Design.

Though storytelling and videos may have limited effects on engineering presentations, I should have considered them as powerful auxiliary tools to capture audience’s attention in other presentations.

Because as an engineer, sometimes I have to explain some basic engineering principles behind the product. When it comes to math, codes and physics, my audience always seems to keep losing focus from me. It's so frustrating to see so many people not understand you.

Garr Reynolds gives a moving talk, telling me how videos, stories and emotion can bring audience closer than they've ever been. And it reminds me that all the fantastic presentations I've heard are filled with splendid stories, no matter they are given by business persons, scientists, engineers or ordinary people. I may even conclude radically that only "emotional" presentations are good presentations. The best thing I learn from this talk is that presentation is about "idea". To make my "idea" clear, I'll have to make it resonate with my audience, and every techniques in presentation should serve this purpose.

About visual aids

- Using visuals makes the speech more interesting
- Visuals also increases your credibility.
- Visual aids should not become the presentation
- Your message is more important than the visual

Being emotionally neutral

vs.

Making an emotional connection

Facts alone fall short

1. WHAT TYPE OF PRESENTATION ARE YOU GIVING?

- *Small meeting*
- *Department or conference seminar*
- *Classroom lecture*
- *Sales pitch / funding request*
- *Workshop*
- *Other*

2. WHO IS YOUR AUDIENCE?

- *Coworkers or colleagues*
- *Managers*
- *Scientists/technical professionals*
- *Salespeople and marketers*
- *Students*
- *Mixed*
- *Other*

3. WHAT IS THE HEADLINE MESSAGE OF YOUR PRESENTATION?

Boiling down my presentation down to my core idea.

If I want my audience to take away a single message from my presentation, what will it be?

- Specific, memorable, concise headlines that your audience can easily remember and share.

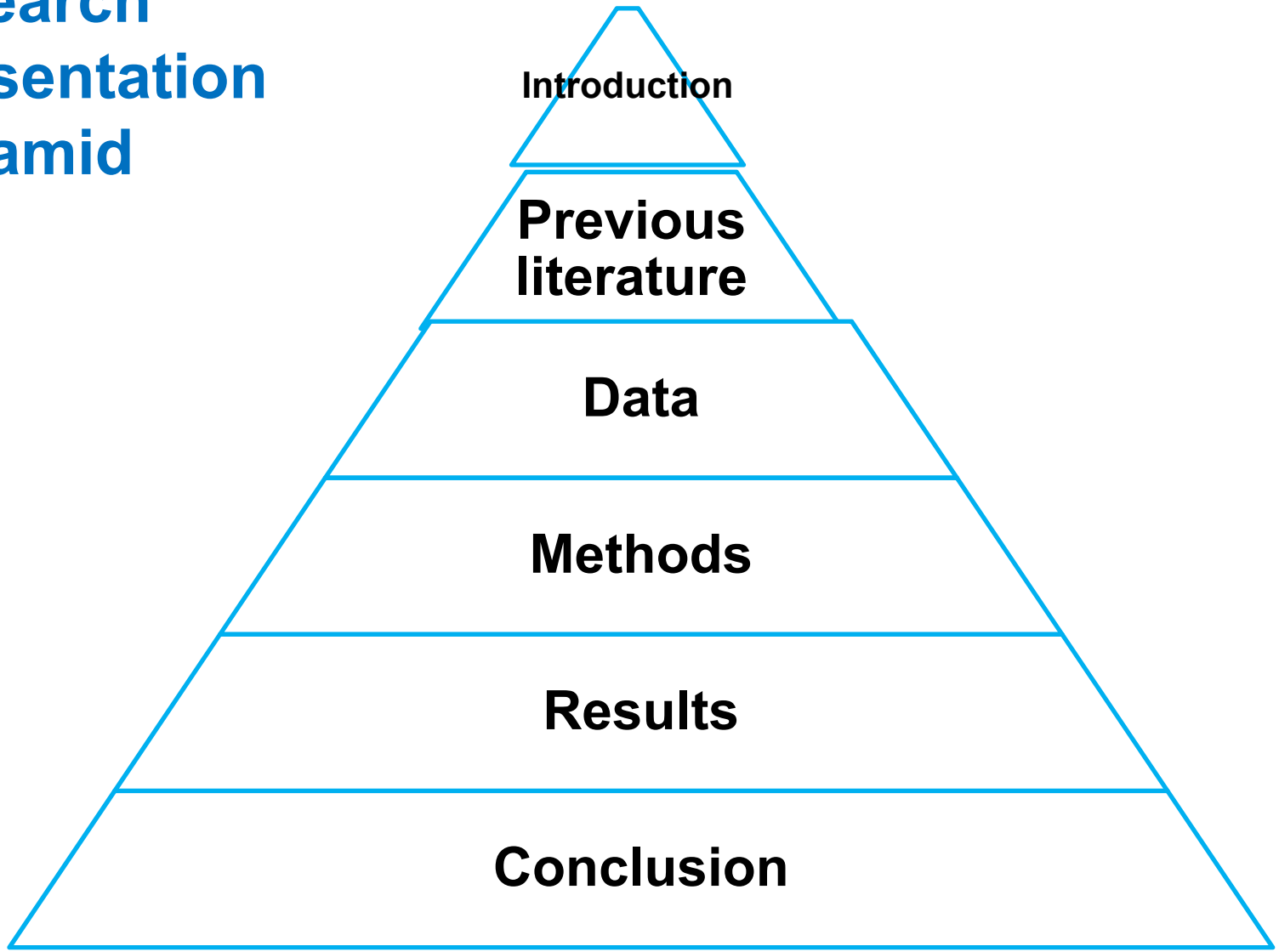
Take your abstract and boil it down to the core.

Example: "*Technology Can Improve Government*" can act as a headline and succinctly grab the audience's attention.

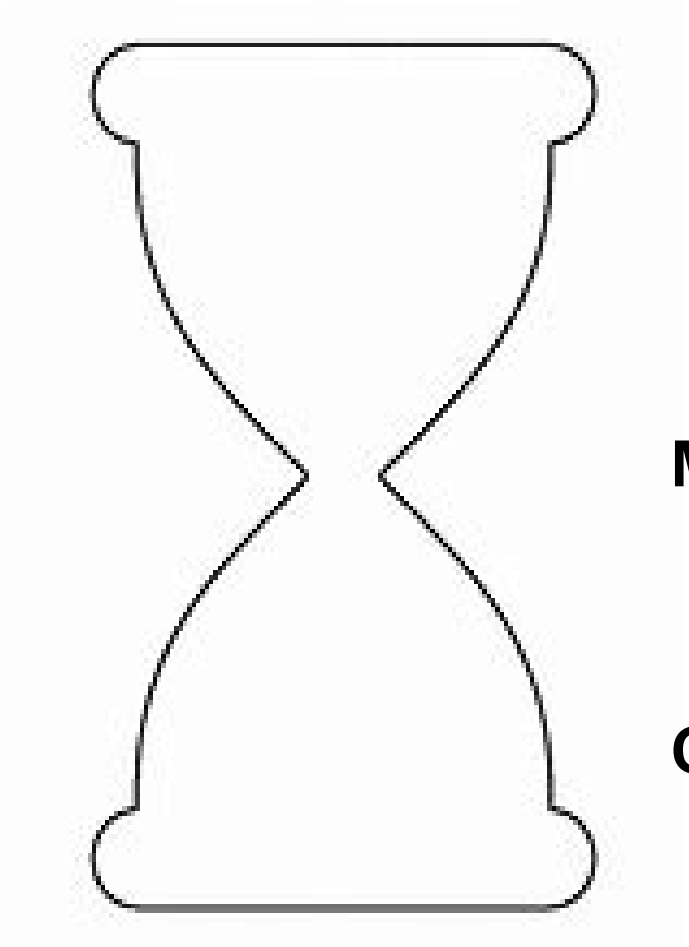
4. WHAT DO YOU WANT YOUR AUDIENCE TO DO WITH YOUR RESULTS & CONCLUSIONS?

- Adopt your methodology?
- Use your data?
- Give you more data?
- Understand your findings and assess the reliability of your results?

Typical research presentation pyramid



The Hourglass structure



Hook and Preview

Methods, Data, & Details

Conclusions & Takeaways

5. CRAFT YOUR OPENING STATEMENT

- Crucial for capturing and keeping audience attention.
- Bold and compelling?

Traditional opening:

Thank you for having me. I'm going to talk about some of the work I've been doing on IT needs in the public sector. Before I begin, let me just say that this paper is in progress and I'm still working with the data. I'm also eager to hear any comments or questions you might have, so I'll be sure to leave time at the end.

Try focusing on the takeaway message

Changes in technology are enabling governments to respond to citizens in vastly different ways, improving efficiency and reducing costs. Those changes are having real impacts on state governments and specific government programs. I have collected data on 150 state agencies from 25 different states, and will show you how improving internal computer systems leads to a 15 percent increase in citizen satisfaction and a 10 percent decrease in costs. My findings show that states that invest $50 million in their internal computer systems will see positive returns on those investments within 5 years.

6. CRAFT YOUR CLOSING STATEMENT.

This is your opportunity to **sum up** your content and **hammer home** your takeaway message.

Traditional closing statement

My results differ from the existing literature because I've used new, better data, and have modified the theoretic model in a variety of ways. The estimates show that improving internal computer systems lead to a 15 percent increase in citizen satisfaction and a 10 percent decrease in costs, which are both pretty large numbers, right? Thank you for your time and I'm happy to answer any questions you might have.

Wrapping your conclusion in a story

Imagine that you are one of the more than 46 million people who currently receive government aid. To apply for benefits, you need to take a day off of work—a big deal when you already live below the poverty line—arrange care for your kids, and maybe take a bus or two to the government office. What a difference it would make to be able to submit the application online.

I've shown you how state agencies have improved their computer systems to make these kinds of processes easier and faster. While costing each state about $50 million on average, these changes have raised citizen satisfaction and engagement, and have improved the way they provide services to participants. Either as researchers working in the area of government and technology or in public support programs like food stamps, or as someone responsible for the computer systems in your agency, I urge you to consider how these technology investments can ultimately improve the lives of people living in your states and your communities.

7. OUTLINE THE SECTIONS OF YOUR PRESENTATION.

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

Use index cards?

8. WHAT STORIES CAN YOU TELL?

- Relate to audience on a human level
- Consider stories that relate to your content and help advance or support your argument.

- *What stories can you use to connect with your audience?*
- *Was there an event that motivated you to undertake this research?*

9. IMAGES

- *Graphs & Charts*
- *Pictures, Illustrations, & Icons*
- *Videos*

10. ANTICIPATED QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS.

- Any questions I could help you with?
- Any comments or suggestions?

3 THINGS TO REMEMBER ABOUT PLANNING

1. **Visualize.** Organize your thoughts and plan your presentation using a process that works for you.

2. **Unify.** Consider how your presentation will hold together and how it might differ from your written report.

3. **Focus.** Move your conclusion to the front and hook your audience right away.

Thank you!

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